

LORD OF THE LEAGUE

IT TOOK HIM NEARLY 14 YEARS TO GET HIS IDEA OFF THE GROUND, BUT THE SCALE OF ITS SUCCESS HAS WIPED OUT MEMORIES OF FAILED ATTEMPTS AND TRIBULATIONS

■ By Shankkar Aiyar

At about 8 p.m. on January 24, a few hours after the hectic bidding for the Indian Premier League (IPL) teams, Lalit Kumar Modi was heading for dinner at The Oberoi in Mumbai. Although the franchisees had bid over \$730 million (Rs 2,920 crore), the IPL chairman was assailed by doubts. Lost in thought, he bumped into Reliance ADAG Chairman Anil Ambani, who had failed to bag a team. Ambani greeted him with a quintessentially blunt "Why only eight teams, why not nine? What will it take to make it happen?" Ambani's fixation made Modi realise he had cracked the "want factor". History was in the making, but it didn't quite sink in till the crowd roared as Kolkata Knight Rider Brendon McCullum hoisted a Zaheer Khan delivery for a six at Bangalore in the first match.

The Monday following the IPL final—watched by 24 million—viewers and channels discussed the 8 p.m. withdrawal symptoms. In just 44 days, Indian cricket and evenings have undergone enormous change. After 59 matches, 2,360 overs, 17,610 runs, 677 wickets, 1,702 boundaries and 622 sixers, there is little doubt that Modi's brainwave has created history. Ironically, when he first aired the IPL idea in January, it had few takers. But Modi lured broadcasters and corporates alike, bagging over \$1.7 billion (Rs 6,800 crore) for BCCI. The sponsors rolled in as he baited them with a spot in the limelight and embedded advertising. DLF, for instance, got billing every time a six was hit. And it all paid off. Thanks to a record viewership of 99 million, Modi raked in a profit of Rs 350 crore for BCCI in the first year.

On the face of it, Modi—a Marwari born in

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1,000

people, including the teams, officials and sponsors, were carted around the country.



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